

WESTERN BALKANS FUND
2020
ANNUAL REPORT



More than 10 thousand people were directly involved or exposed as part of the Western Balkans Fund projects in 2020. From the appealing sounds of Balkan Youth Orchestra to new ways paved to discover our region by bike, to celebrate together culture and music, to discover our shared Roman heritage, to work together in research and education, and even to create joint solutions in nursing, care, and green mobility – all these were the impressive results enabled by the grantees selected out of over 1000 NGOs who applied in our 3rd call for proposals last year. Very proud that this year contributed further for a better region for us all - a region where exchange, fruitful relations, and cooperation between people at all levels - and from all walks of life - is the norm rather than the exception.

About the WBF Annual Report

Western Balkans Fund presents its yearly progress on annual basis. The content of this report includes five chapters: grant making, strategic perspective, promotion, partnership and networking in regional and international level.

As the Regional Projects are the most important tool of implementation of our objectives, our Reports are organized following the Calls for Applications and the project cycle execution. This Report covers the 3-rd Call of WBF.



Findings and Interpretations

Information and data collected presented in this report were conducted by the staff of the Western Balkans Fund with external contributions. The findings, interpretations and conclusions expressed in the chapter where projects supported by WBF do not necessarily reflect the views of Western Balkans Fund, its Committee of Senior Officials, or the governments they represent. The WBF does not guarantee the accuracy of the data included in this chapter more specifically information related to the grantees reports and data.

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Message from Executive Director



Dear Partners, Colleagues and Friends of Western Balkans Fund,

I am very happy to share the Annual Report of Western Balkans Fund for the year 2020. This third edition of the report is a joint product of the Secretariat, aiming to inform about Fund's main achievements.

The past year has marked a real challenge for the Western Balkans Fund (WBF) and overall regional cooperation processes. The challenging context imposed by the Covid 19 Pandemic, called for a more active role to support and adapt according to the needs of the flimsy condition of the Civil society in our region.

While the exceptionalism of COVID-19 dared our sense of normality by imposing isolation and limited mobility, we successfully continued pursuing our goals.

Western Balkans Fund showed commitment and strong capacities to respond to the unprecedented situation by mobilizing a series of adaptations to its partnership and support approach.

Despite the challenges presented, in this report you will find a detailed and in-depth information about the 23 regional projects we have supported in the Pandemic year 2020. The WBF is also proud of all the other vivid activities which took part in 2020 including mentorship and monitoring, internship program, networking, and fundraising efforts etc.

WBF is enthusiastically dedicated to "people-to-people" approach and 85 organizations in the region are involved to help us achieve this inclusive aim, as they work in joint projects in the region, financed by WBF.

Interventions vary from cycling the region, to university exchanges, joint research, cultural heritage, music festivals, tourism promotion, enabling more qualitative life to elderly, giving full space and attention to nurses, internships of students in universities within the Western Balkans, and much more.

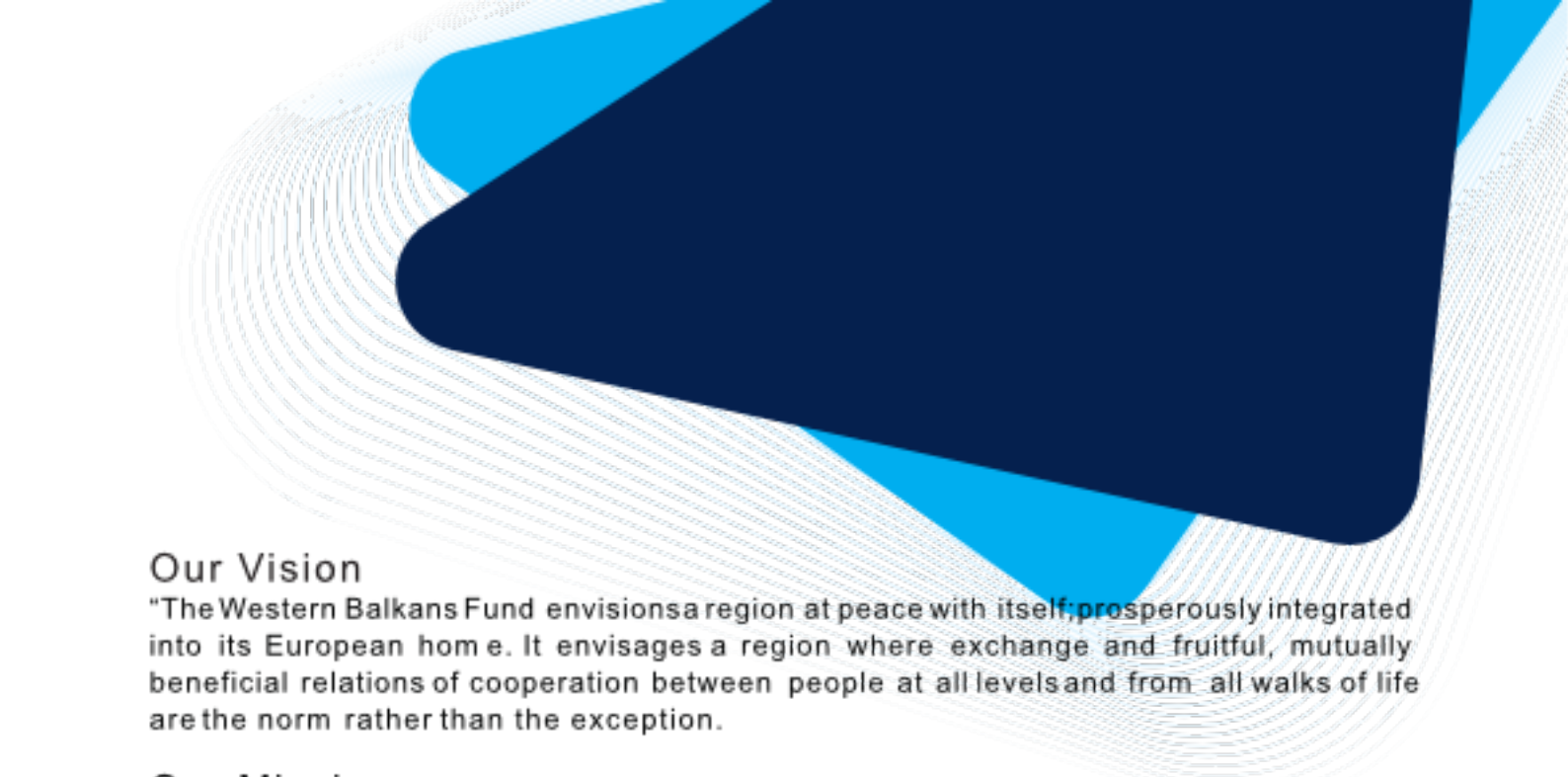
For more insights about our work, I would leave you to check the report and appreciate the variety of our operations and its concrete results through figures and facts.

We are assured that constructive collaboration in the approaching year will bring growth and progress while strengthening positive regional bonds.

All of us, at Western Balkans Fund, are looking forward to the period ahead, as an important cornerstone in our organizational development with concrete plans for further institutional consolidation and growth.

We are confident that you share the same excitement with us, as we work, share, and promote the region we all call "Home", and are keen to browse through the Western Balkans positive vibes. We remain proud of the achievements and cannot wait to work with many more organizations as we continue to support common projects.

Having said that, on behalf of WBF Team, I wish to thank all our collaborators, supporters, partners, grantees, and our friends! Without your constructive and treasurable partnership this progress would not have been possible!



Our Vision

"The Western Balkans Fund envisions a region at peace with itself, prosperously integrated into its European home. It envisages a region where exchange and fruitful, mutually beneficial relations of cooperation between people at all levels and from all walks of life are the norm rather than the exception.

Our Mission

Fund's mission is to promote:

- The development of closer cooperation and strengthening of ties between the Western Balkans Contracting Parties;
- The integration of the Contracting Parties into the European Union;
- Common presentation of the WBF Contracting Parties to the third countries.

Our Values

- **Regional Cooperation** - WBF exists because of the people of the region. Its mission is to provide investments in regional cooperation in such a way that they translate to tangible benefits for the people of the region.
- **Transparency**: Information about activities and overall management has always been publicly available because the WBF believes that openness and accountability is very important.
- **People to People Links**: WBF is available to all civil society initiatives of the region, regardless of their religious and/or any other beliefs, the language they use or any other personal characteristics.
- **Efficiency**: The WBF strives to achieve the best possible results with the minimum resources. The principle of efficiency is, therefore, applied both in the implementation of projects and administration. The salaries paid in the WBF are in accordance with the non-profit sector's standards, while the overhead costs are kept to the minimum required for efficient operations.
- **Effectiveness**: The WBF attaches great importance to achieving clear and concrete results and has developed mechanisms to monitor its work and the results of its projects. As such, the strategic plan represents the basis of cooperation between the Western Balkans Fund and civil society around the Western Balkans region, by committing the financial support of six governments in creating favorable conditions for strengthening regional cooperation.

Operating under COVID19pandemic

The advent of Covid-19 and all its health, security, social and political fallout represents a new challenge for the Western Balkans Fund (WBF) and overall regional cooperation processes. In the conditions when gains achieved in regional cooperation are still fragile and in the context of regional fragmentation, there is no time to retrench behind borders and boundaries.

The Civil Society Organizations across the region faced substantial difficulties. In general, they were left out from Government support schemes and struggled with the impact of the pandemic on their funding, communications and human capital. Those who adapted quicker, survived easier. Those who didn't, struggled to navigate this new un-predicted world full of restrictions, but also with opportunities.

Meanwhile, those who do not favor the growth of regional cooperation, may perceive the pandemic as a way of reinterpreting the notion of 'social distancing' into a permanent practice – the very antithesis of regional cooperation.

True, the pandemic made people-to-people contact almost impossible in the short-term. One of our concerns is that the fear of infection will be stoked to create long-term opposition to regional exchange, and thus undermine the nascent culture of regional mobility that the WBF seeks to enable. As organizations struggled financially in the wake of the pandemic, many still find themselves in survival mode, and do not perceive regional connectivity as critical to their survival.

Donors surely, have to step up and prove them wrong. This is the time to reinforce all the myriad ways that organizations and communities can reach out to each other across our region. The pandemic is a wake-up call for us all to reinvent regional cooperation. Unless we take now concerted action to adapt donor programs, the gains made in recent years could be reversed.

Nourishing a new culture of labor under Covid-19 and Applying the Strategy with flexibility

Fund's new five-year Strategy reflects an ability to adapt and flexibility in order to respond nimbly and effectively in a volatile political, economic and social (and now, public health) environment. In newly created situation of political, social and economic volatility, far too little investment is being made in direct support toward the Civil Society sector in the region. WBF has learned that in such situation increased and sustained investment is very much needed in order to reach tangible benefits towards active citizenship, democratic societies and healthy regional cooperation.

A tangible and valuable Strategic plan cannot hold the organization hostage to fixed approaches that no longer make sense when the whole dynamic of work has changed around the world, six months after the plan was written.

Thus, with the rapid spread of the pandemic, the Fund immediately mobilized a series of adaptations to its partnership and support approach aiming delivering results:

- The Secretariat was fully operational, using a combined working method onsite and remote.
- The Fund's grant making portfolio is more targeted. The support to the individual needs and circumstances of all partners was adapted. Contract negotiations and advisory meetings and monitoring continued, unabated.
- The main challenge for the Fund, was to ensure the smooth implementation of each supported project, while not jeopardizing the desired impact & mitigating the risks.
- WBF program team provided hands-on support to grantees, with a maximum flexibility for best possible solution and prepared back-up plans for transforming physical activities in virtual ones

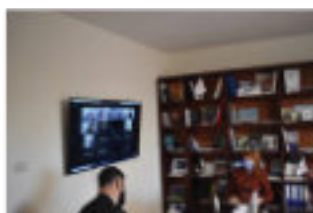
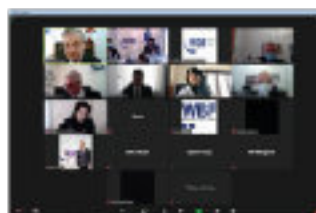
Key Activities of WBF Governing Bodies

The WBF Council of Senior Officials met 2 times During the year 2020. Due to the situation with the Covid 19 Pandemic and to fully respect the safety measures, the meetings, organized in September and December were organized in a mixed format, with some of the participants being present at WBF Secretariat and some on-line.

During these Meetings the activities and achievements of the Initiative were discussed and the Council took the necessary decisions, paving the way to further activities of the Secretariat in the upcoming period.

These Meetings constituted another positive message of the good cooperation spirit between WB Contracting Parties and of their willingness to continue supporting WBF.

Close contacts were kept with the members of the Council of Senior Officials and especially with the Chairmanship-in-Office with the purpose to facilitate the operations and planning of the milestone activities of the Fund in the conditions when human contacts and exchange were limited.



WBF Third Call

The Third Call for Proposals was launched on 28 October 2019. Deadline for submission of Project Proposals was 10 December 2019. The overall objective of the Call was to contribute to regional cooperation, and strengthen regional cohesion in the WB6 region. The Call has foreseen three main areas of intervention through which applicants could have submitted their applications:

1. Cultural cooperation
2. Education and scientific exchanges
3. Sustainable development

Promoting cross-border cooperation, European integration, gender equality and matters pertaining to youth are the crosscutting issues covering all actions under WBF key areas of activities.

- The overall indicative amount made available under this Call for proposals was EUR 250,000
- Any grant requested should not exceed EUR 12,000.
- The applicant should have provided at least 20% of the total costs of the project.
- The planned duration of a project should not exceed 12 months.
- It was foreseen to have 24 projects awarded, same as last year.

The project partnerships represented the central requirement of the Call:

- ❑ Project partnership consisted of the lead-applicant and minimum two project partners.
- ❑ Partnership parties must come from at least three different WB6 Contracting Parties.

Eligible applicants were the following:

- ① Civil society organizations (NGOs)
- ② Local or regional public entities including municipalities or regional development agencies, etc.
- ③ Business associations including: business clusters, agriculture associations, chamber of commerce, tourism associations, etc.
- ④ Educational institutions including universities, schools, institutes, libraries, research centers, academies of science/music/art, etc.
- ⑤ Institutions of culture or sports including museums, art galleries, theatres, or associations of cultural institutions, sport

Dissemination

The Call was actively disseminated through online and social media channels:

Web Page: www.westernbalkansfund.org;

Facebook: <https://www.facebook.com/WesternBalkansFund>;

Twitter: <https://twitter.com/Balkans.fund>

Instagram: <https://www.instagram.com/westernbalkansfund/>

LinkedIn: <https://www.linkedin.com/company/westernbalkansfund/>

For its dissemination WBF Secretariat organized twelve Information Sessions, being present for the first time not only in the capitals. The Info Sessions resulted in great interest and high expectations from the civil society organizations (CSO), universities, schools, associations of arts, culture and sports, local authorities, chambers of commerce and industry, media organizations and other non-profit stakeholders.

More than 700 participants in the sessions were informed in details about the Call and more than 70 direct questions and recommendations were recorded.



Vlora - 1 November



Tirana - 4 November



Ferizaj - 6 November



Bjelo Polje - 7 November



Podgorica- 11November



Sarajevo- 13November



Banja Luka- 14November



Belgrade - 18November



Nis - 19November



Skopje- 20 November



Prishtina - 21November

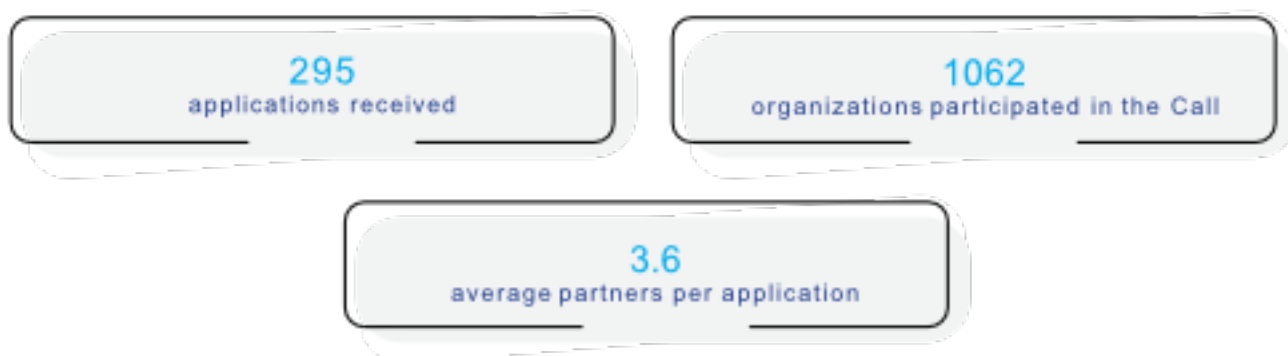
About

The Partnership Platform

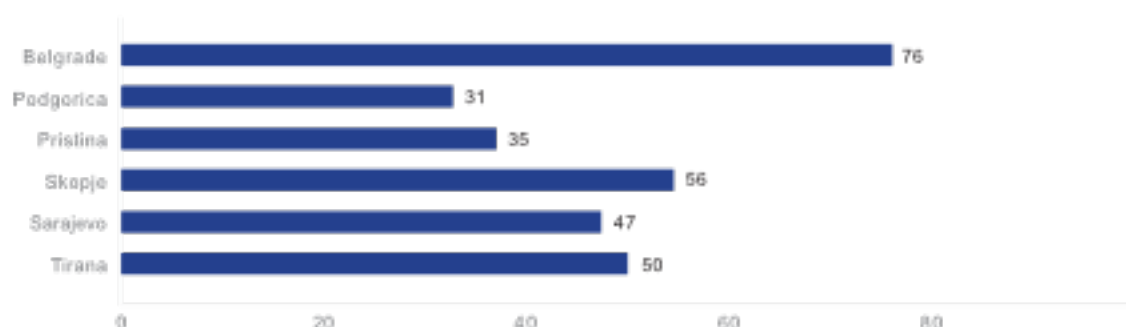
This Third Call, once again confirmed WBF Online Partnership Platform, as a useful virtual tool, a meeting point for organizations wishing to engage in regional projects and looking for suitable partners. This platform, utilized by both small and newly established organizations and those with a significant track record counts more than 1200 active members.

The Call in Figures

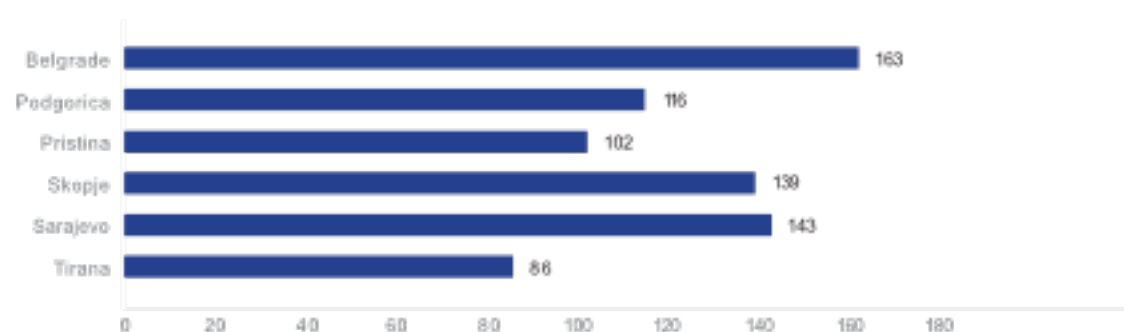
Within this Call, WBF received in total 295 applications out of which were supported 23 regional projects. All project activities conducted by WBF grantees took place in the WB6 region. WBF continued with its main requirement to establish partnership among applicants that consists lead-applicant and minimum two project partners, which partners shall come from at least three different WB6 Contracting Parties. According to the WBF's assessment, 1062 organizations have participated in this call either as a lead-applicant or as the project partner. The variety of grant beneficiaries was evident in the 3d Call for Proposals that included: Chambers of Commerce, Municipalities, Sport Associations, Women Organizations, Media Associations Writers Associations, Theatres and Museums.



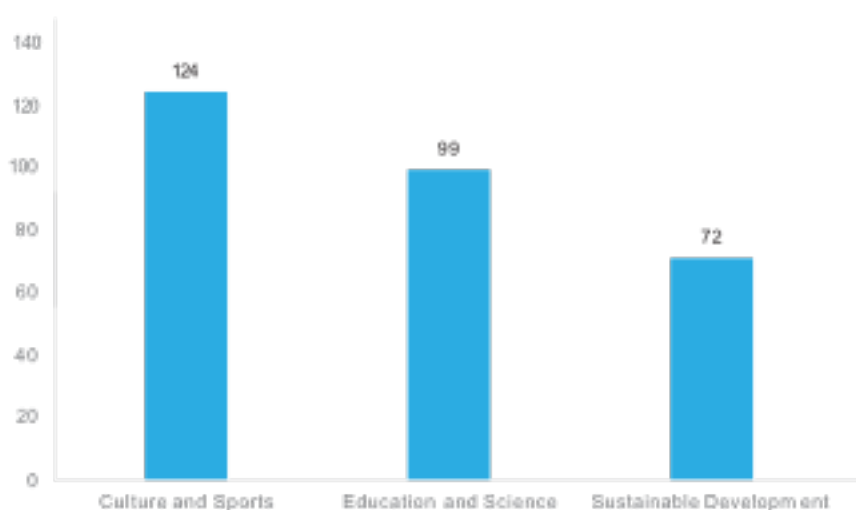
Allocation of projects per Contracting Party



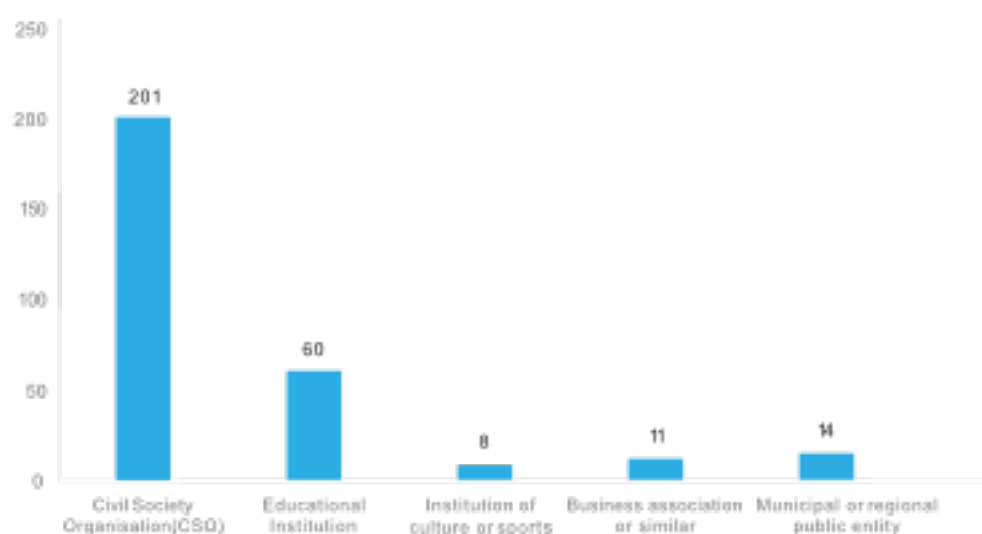
Allocation of partnerships per Contracting Party



Allocation per area of intervention



Allocation per type of applicant



Selecting WBF New Partners

Within a period of 2 months, WBF experts managed to effectively assess 271 applications that resulted eligible. Through the professional assessment by the evaluation units, all projects were classified and ranked, strictly following the evaluation guidelines. The best ranking projects were selected and they were further evaluated by the WBF Evaluation Committee, which prepared the list of recommended projects, to be further approved/endorsed by the WBF CSO and WBF Conference of MFA.

Right after the conclusion of the in-house evaluation, the outburst of the Covid19 Pandemic happened, causing a general isolation and the temporary suspension of operations including the physical meetings of the WBF Council of Senior Officials and the Conference of Ministers of Foreign Affairs. However, with the support of WBF Chairmanship-in-Office, the List was approved online by silent procedure.

List of Winning Projects of WBF 3rd Call

Contracting Party	Name of the project	Lead applicant	Partner organizations in the project	Thematic Area
BELGRADE	From sustainable mobility to sustainable peace	Ulice za Bicikliste	Centar za životnu sredinu, BiH; Priroda i društvo- Bajkultura, BiH; Bicklo.me, Montenegro; GDZ, Albania	Cultural Cooperation and Sustainable Development
	Camerata Balcanica –United through music	ArtLink	ArtPlus, Albania; International Peace Centre, BiH	Cultural Cooperation
	Regional Capital (ReCap) Market	IMPACT HUB	Create Foundation, Kosovo*; Student Business Centre, Montenegro	Sustainable Development
	Regional Green Youth Charter	European Movement in Serbia	Centre for Ecology and Energy, BiH; Democracy for Development, Kosovo*; NGO ALPHA Center, Montenegro	Sustainable Development
PODGORICA	Balkan Youth Jazz Orchestra	JAZZ Art Association	Academy of Music at Goce Delchev University, Stip North Macedonia; Faculty of Music, University of Arts in Belgrade, Serbia	Cultural Cooperation
	Illyrians a common heritage	Academy of Social Sciences	Library "Slovo", Serbia; Zenica City Museum, BiH; SWC Beta, Skopje, Centre for culture "Nikola Đurković" Kotor, Montenegro	Education and Scientific Exchange
	Strengthening role of women in promoting peace and cooperation in Western Balkan region through capacity building and education	Center for Local and Regional Development Support	Center for psychological support Sensus, BiH; Center for biopolitical education, BIOPOLIS, Serbia; Udruženje Svetlost – Association Light Serbia	Sustainable Development through Women Empowerment
	European identity and the European value system as connecting points of the Western Balkans	SOCEN	Humanistic studies of the University of Donja Gorica, Montenegro; Faculty of Political Science of the University of Belgrade, Serbia; Faculty of Political Sciences, University of Sarajevo, BiH	Education and Scientific Exchange
PRISTINA	International Congress on Nursing	Chamber of Nurses	Chamber of Nurses, North Macedonia; Chamber of Nurses, Albania; Chamber of Nurses, Montenegro; Chamber of Nurses, Slovenia	Education and Scientific Research
	Regional Conference "Economic Impact and Consequences of the Crisis"	Chamber of Doing Business in Kosovo	North-West Chamber of Businesses, North Macedonia; Chamber of Commerce - Vlora, Albania	Sustainable Development and Culture
	Regional Cooperation on Global Consulting Day 2020	Business Consultants Council	Montenegro Business Alliance, Montenegro; Economic Chamber of North-West Macedonia, North Macedonia; Chamber of Commerce – Industry Tirana, Albania	Sustainable Development
	The role of urban planning on migration	EKONOMIKS	Asociacioni i Arkitektëve të Kosovës, Kosovo*; Klub Finih Zanata, Serbia; Rakatrak HabitArt Academy, North Macedonia; Place, Make, Bulgaria	Education and Scientific Exchange

*This designation is without prejudice to positions on status, and is in line with UNSCR 1244 and the ICJ Opinion on the Kosovo Declaration of Independence.

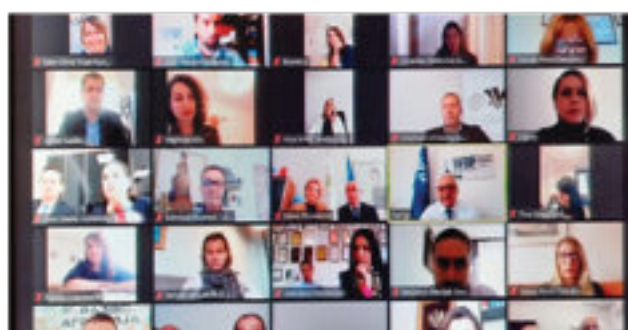
Contracting Party	Name of the project	Lead applicant	Partner organizations in the project	Thematic Area
SARAJEVO	Roman heritage in the Balkans	DIGI.BA	Institute of Archaeology Belgrade (IAB), Serbia; European University of Tirana (EUT), Albania; NGO Montenegro, Montenegro.	Cultural Cooperation
	Enhancing Competencies and Practical Skills - ECPS	CIDEA	(School for Hospitality, Trade and Tourism Banja Luka), BiH; JU Ugošteljsko-ekonomska škola Prijedor, BiH; GRM Novo Mesto –center biotehni-ke in turizma, Slovenia; Srednja škola za gostinstvo in turizam Maribor, Slovenia; Srednja gostinska in turistična škola Radovljica, Slovenia; Trgovinsko-ugostiteljska škola Leskovat, Serbia; Ugošteljsko-turistička škola Beograd, Serbia; Ekonomsko-trgovinska škola Smederevo, Serbia; JU SMS "Ivan Goran Kovačić" Herceg Novi, Montenegro; JU Srednja ekonomsko-ugostiteljska škola Bar, Montenegro; OUTU „Vanoč Proseki“ –Ohrid, North Macedonia; SOU „Sv.Naum Ohridski“ Makedonski Brod, North Macedonia; Ugošteljska turistička škola, Croatia; Ugošteljska škola Opatija, Croatia	Education and Scientific Exchange
	Increasing Research Capacities of WB CSOs in the Area of Organized	Center for Security Studies	Institute for Democracy and Mediation (IDM), Albania; Kosovar Centre for Security Studies (KCSS), Kosovo; EuroThink, North Macedonia; Institute Alternative (IA), Montenegro; Belgrade Centre for Security Policy (BCSP), Serbia	Education and Scientific Exchange
	Healthy Aging	Public institution "retirement home with a stationary" in Zenica Canton	Caritas of the Diocese of Banja Luka, BiH; Association "Creatives" Zenica, BiH; Public Institution Home for Elderly "Grabovac", Rijan, Montenegro; Gerontology Center Vrsac (Gerontološki centar Vrsac), Serbia	Sustainable Development
SKOPJE	Ohrid Treat	Ohrid Tercat	Association „Zdrav Život –KINEZIS“, BiH; Trail Running, Albania	Cultural Cooperation
	WB Group on Political Orientalism	Institute for Sociological, Political and Juridical Research (ISPJR-UKIM)	Faculty of Social Sciences, University of Tirana, Albania; Faculty of Philosophy, University of Belgrade, Serbia	Education and Scientific Exchange
	Partnership for circular economy –sustainable SMEs growth and regional development	Youth Entrepreneurial Service Foundation	Albanian Socio-Economic Think Tank - ASET, Albania; Foundation for innovation and technology development, BiH.	Sustainable Development
	WB Cultours	BALKAN NETWORK FOR LOCAL DEMOCRACY	P1 Local Democracy Agency of Mostar, BiH; Local Democracy Agency Montenegro, Montenegro; Local Democracy Agency of Central and South Serbia, Serbia; Local Democracy Agency of Kosovo, Kosovo*	Cultural Cooperation
TIRANA	Butrinti Summer Festival- 18th edition	Q.K.T.M.National Centre of Mediterranean Theatre	Association Magic Lamp, Serbia; Peripetija Production, North Macedonia; Rinia Aktive e Gjakoves, Kosovo*.	Cultural Cooperation
	Strengthening regional academic and research exchange	LUARASI University	FON university, North Macedonia; University of Zenica, BiH; Donja Gorica University, Montenegro	Education and Scientific Exchange
	Youth skills development through New Media	TULLA Center	Naroden Teater Bitola, North Macedonia; AniBar, Kosovo*	Cultural Cooperation
	Improving children rights monitoring mechanisms around Western Balkan region	Observatory for Children and Youth Rights	Macedonian Center for Women's Rights, North Macedonia; Network of Roma, Ashkali and Egyptian Women's Organization, Kosovo*	Education and Scientific Exchange

Awarding Ceremony

Online “Meet and Greet” Grant 2020 Awarding ceremony – WBF conducted virtual awarding ceremony on May 26th, 2020. This event provided the 23 awarded partners with opportunity to learn about WBF’s approach to regional cooperation and about the support they can count on while building better neighborly relations.

Workshops with 2020 awarded grantees – aiming to inform in depth the grantees about grant implementation rules and procedures. In total, WBF organized three on-line workshops over the course of June 01-02, 2020. WBF, nurturing its values and respect for diversity, invited two CP’s per workshop, as follows: Podgorica and Pristina; Tirana and Belgrade; Sarajevo and Skopje.

The Grant Contracts were signed by the grantees and submitted to the WBF Secretariat Headquarters by mail.



PROJECTS

Note: An elaborated process of negotiations was conducted prior to the signing of the Grant Contracts, to align the activities of each projects with the new circumstances created by the Covid 19. Still, 2 from the BiH projects, withdrew from the implementation considering their activities as impossible to implement under the limitations created by the measures against the Pandemic. The following info presented, describes the 23 projects implemented under the WBF 3rd Call.



CULTURE

(36% OF TOTAL PROJECTS)

“Balkan Youth Jazz Orchestra”, implemented by JAZZ Art Association

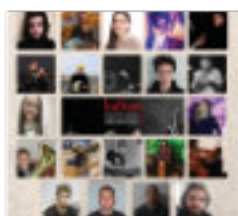


A musical experience unlike any with the Balkan Youth Jazz Orchestra. Western Balkans Fund, through this innovative project, is proudly bringing people together through music.

Young composers, players and musicians combine their knowledge of contemporary classical music with ideas present in jazz, in many domains, contributing not only to orchestration and composition, but also in enjoying togetherness through music. This amazing project is a showcase of the real cultural cooperation and is the result of a joint, multicultural, and cross-border youth jazz orchestra.

Balkan Youth Jazz Orchestra is a beacon of change, and it helps bringing closer young musicians to the mission of WBF's – which is regional cooperation, good neighborly relations and strengthening of the regional cohesion in the WB region.

This project serves as a base for creating regional connections and networks of young jazz musicians and composers, as well as for strengthening the cooperation between partner institutions, all to improve and promote talented musicians and composers living and creating in the Balkans



"From sustainable mobility to sustainable peace", implemented by Ulice za bicikliste, Belgrade

 **Ulice za bicikliste** Discover Western Balkans amazing scenery, roads, culture, people, summer. Take that bike and group of friends and cycle in our amazing region. Unsure of the roads, destinations and spots? No need to be! All you need to do is to download the app on Balkan Cycling and have an experience you never thought you could. Ask the 15 young people who did take the trip. The group of enthusiasts took a 15-days bike caravan in 5 focal cities in the Western Balkans. The app developed for an easier ride and discovery helped the youth to experience the region at another level, full of adrenaline, common scope and aim. 25 focal activities helped the organized to reach the final stage (bike tour). To enable that, excessive preparations took place in the form of lectures, meetings held with local stakeholders, sites visit (to museums, ethnos-villages, national parks, etc.), cleaned and/or beautified 5 public spaces. 15 people started this adventure, but the number got to 300 attendees in the multiple peer-to-peer educational activities as the group prepared to experience Western Balkans by bike.

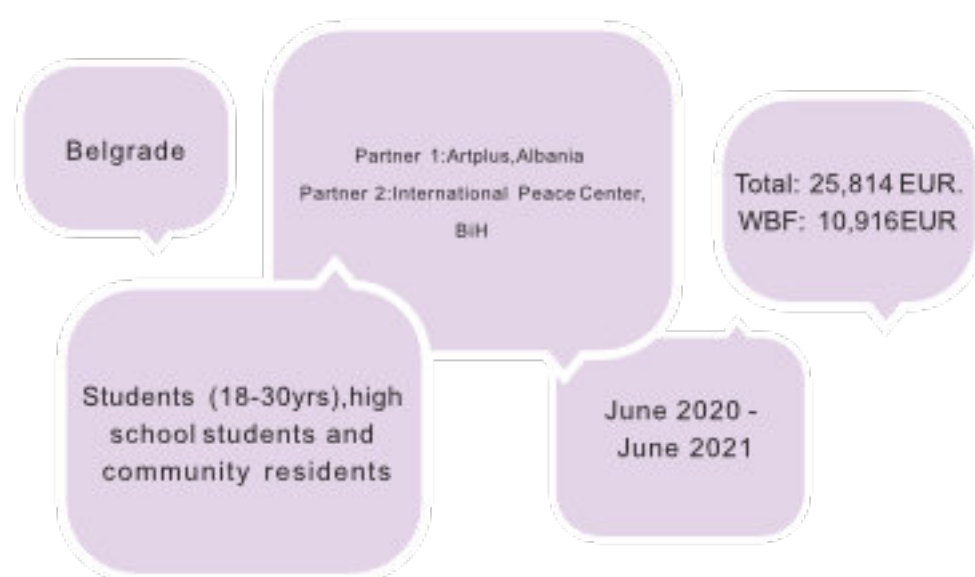


"Camerata Balcanica – United Through Music", implemented by Artlink



Have you heard yet the concerts of 12 young musicians from all the Balkans? They've performed in Belgrade, Novi Sad and Tirana. If you've missed the chance, you can still enjoy the rhythm of togetherness that Camerata Balcanica inspires in their audio, CD and Video, featuring the live performances by the amazing band that unites people through music.

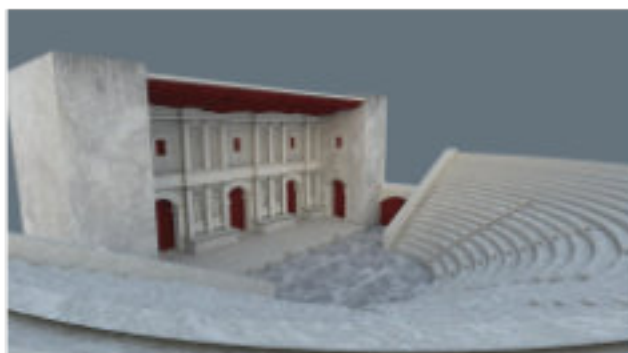
This project aimed showcasing the positive effects of joint youth creativity within and beyond the region under the motto "United Through Music";



"Roman heritage in the Balkans", implemented by DIGI.BA, Sarajevo



How would you like a virtual tour on the common Roman cultural heritage we share in the Balkans? Digi.Ba partners have made a video that takes us back in time and walk us through the whole region in a very attractive approach via storytelling and VR application. It takes just a few minutes to visit virtually the monuments in Bosnia and Herzegovina, Serbia, Montenegro, and Albania showing how our region shares this common cultural heritage demonstrated in Roman villa and terme in Ilidza near Sarajevo, Roman military camp and city Viminacium near Pozarevac, Serbia, Municipium settlement near Pljevlja, Montenegro and Durres amphitheater in Albania, all presented through VR storytelling. The user-friendly application is available online and installed in local museums, close to the selected archaeological sites. It allows the Internet users and museum visitors to take a virtual walk-through Balkans in the Roman period and learn about monuments preserved only in fragments in selected sites and listening to relevant explanations. The project is also improving cooperation and exchange between experts such as archaeologists, historians, IT people, moviemakers in the region.



"Ohrid running weekend 2020", implemented by OHRID TRCAT, Ohrid



The initiative aimed to change the way in which sport is currently recognized only as connected to physical wellbeing. Based on the cooperation and the exchange of practices, Ohrid Trcat will continue to aim at initiating topics to be addressed in the future such as enhancing the societal role of sport, promoting public health through physical activity, boosting volunteer activities, enhancing the economic dimension of sport and the free movement of players, fighting doping, corruption and hooliganism. Over 500 participants took part in the 5k and 21k marathon races. As parallel activities to the main event, project partners implemented two workshops on the topic of challenges and advantages of organizing sports events in light of a global pandemic and volunteering on sports events, where participants got actively engaged and shared their experience and know-how.



“WB Cultours Cultural tours in Western Balkans”, implemented by Balkan Network for Local Democracy (BNLD), Skopje

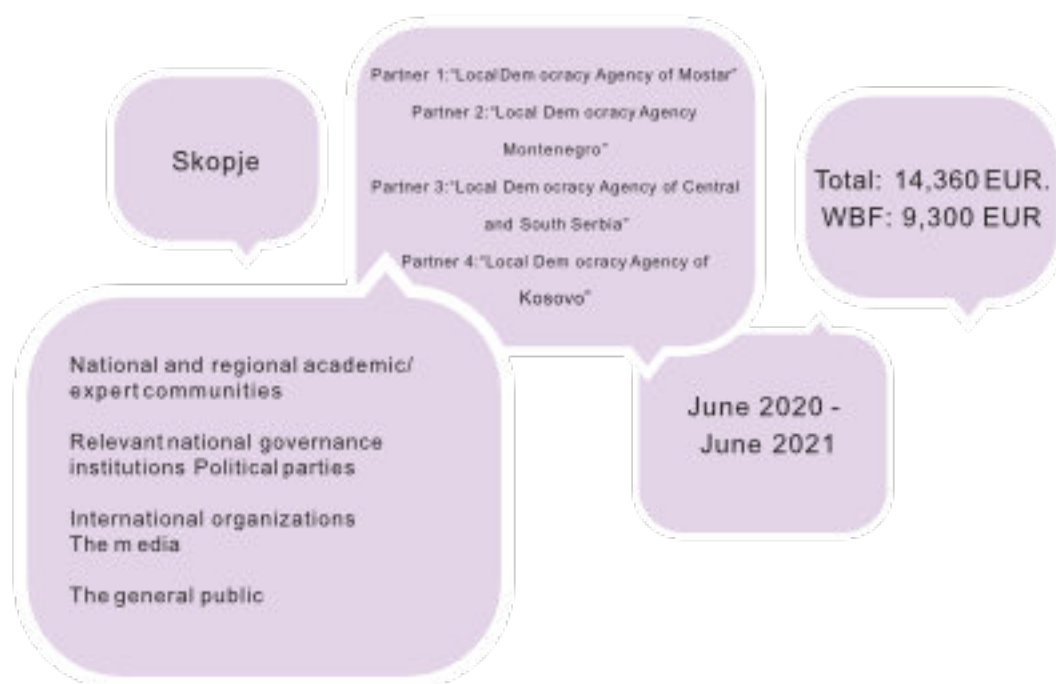


Balkan Network for Local Democracy

Tourism, local ideas, regional solutions: all encountered in the forum “Western Balkans Tourism in the spotlight”, organized to connect the Western Balkans through tourism, offering the chance to touristic workers and

stakeholders from WB6 to meet and talk in the frame of this project. The event was part of a series of discussions and short presentations in an open forum, sharing experiences from the Balkans. It offered a great meeting point to network, make connections and even create a joint touristic offer.

Touristic guides, workers and enthusiasts shared their experience about the topic of Tourism in Western Balkans. A special treat: Cultours, the mobile application that offers 3 tours to visit 9 monuments in the Western Balkans was promoted.



"Butrinti Summer Festival" – 18 Edition, implemented by National Center of Mediterranean Theatre, Tirana



In a festive spirit to celebrate the start of summer season in Albania, organizers of the Butrinti Film Festival presented in Saranda the documentary "The future begins today". A dynamic atmosphere with the presence of many friends and public in the coastal city. The documentary "The future begins today", supported by the Western

Balkans Fund brings history, experiences and cultural exchange between many artists from all our region!

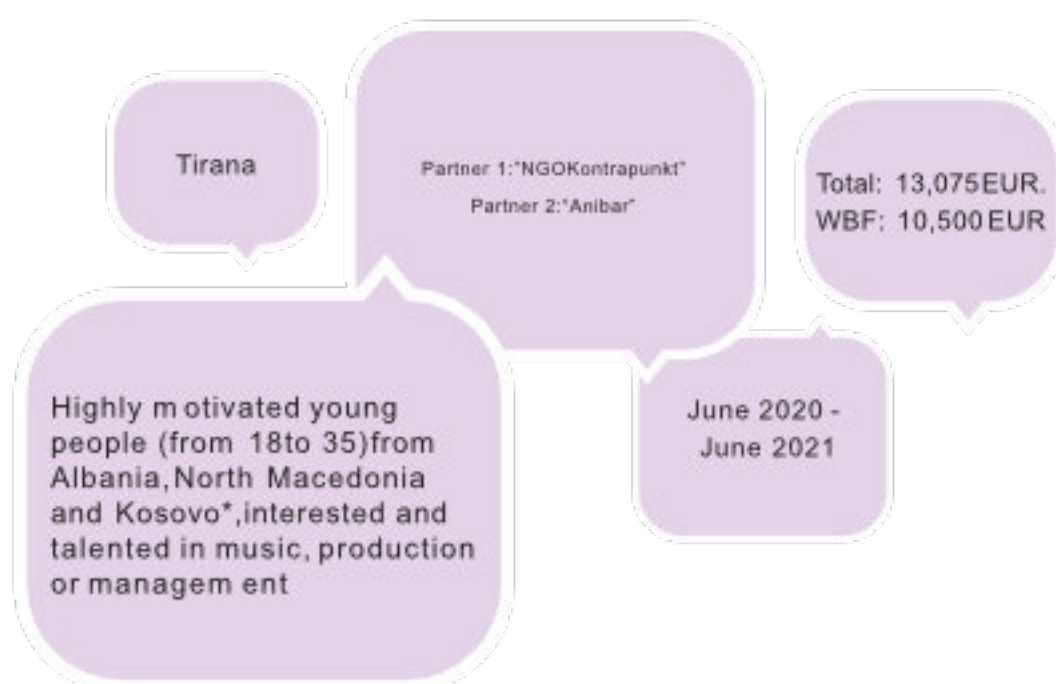


“Youth skills development through New Media”, implemented by TULLA–Culture Center, Tirana



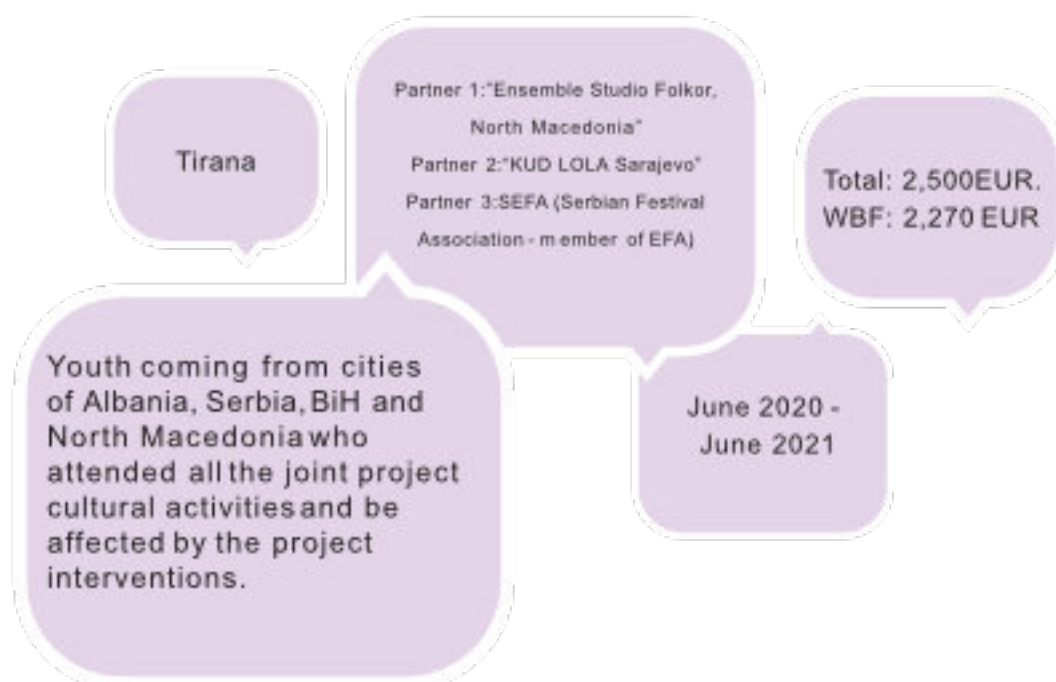
Western Balkans future lies in its young people and its talents, that continue to flourish each and every day in world's scene. Having a large young population in Europe under 25 years old, it presents the need to harness their skills and continue investing in them in modern and alternative education.

TULLA–Culture Centre, through this project aimed to pilot a music production academy with a focus in new media, including skills in production and art management by training at least 40 young participants in the music industry every year.



"Recognizing Economic Advantages of Cultural Heritage (REACH)", implemented by Culture and Arts Center Korca

The project was mainly focused around putting up a virtual stage with rich folklore music which promoted the traditional music, the costumes, the lyrics, the symbols, folk dances etc and highlighted how the beauty of each CP makes up a culturally rich region. The new reality under the COVID 19 pandemic brought the need to create online options to promote the rich cultural heritage. So, the project created virtual meeting, joint videos with songs and dances with Balkan common motives. The videos of the traditional songs and dances were an added value for the 4 partners to enable better promotion, knowledge and the importance of the cultural heritage in the region.





EDUCATION & SCIENTIFIC RESEARCH

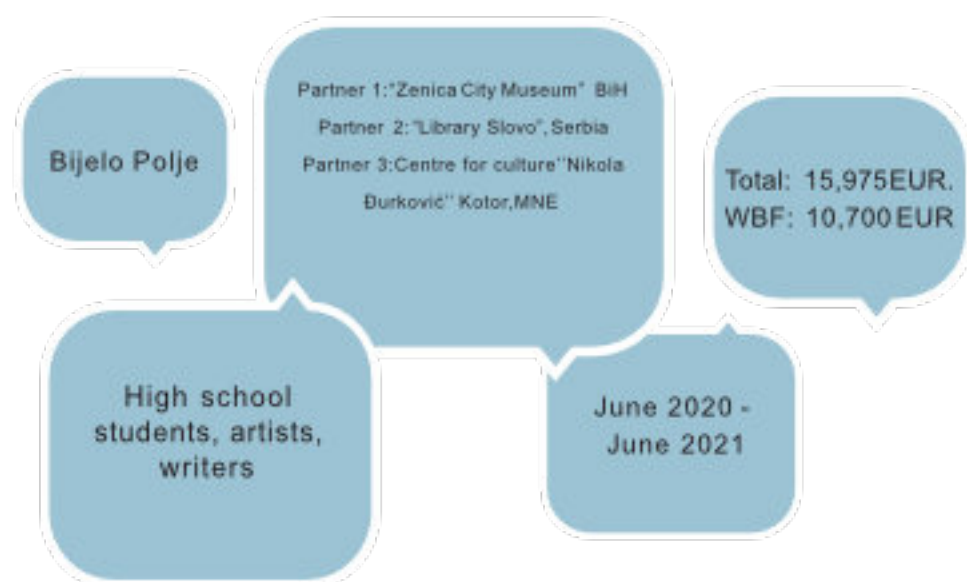
(32% OF TOTAL PROJECTS)

“A comm on heritage Culture, Art, Literature”, implem ented by Academy of Social Sciences Illyrians, Bijelo Polje



The project aimed to connect writers, artists and students from the region in order to establish cooperation and to highlight comm on Illyrian heritage in architecture, art, literature.

Through creative writing and comic book workshops, the students were offered an opportunity to exchange knowledge on comm on heritage and expresstheir views in a creative manner. Upon the conclusion of the workshops, all writers were invited to submit their fantasy and fiction short stories about Ancient Illyrian history and kingdoms which were published and promoted.



“European Identity and the European value system as connecting points of the Western Balkans”, implemented by Sociological Centre of Montenegro – SOCEN, Podgorica



Think of a Regional School of European Integration. Think Budva, Socen and WBF. It gives the full picture of an inspiring closing event: Three day summer schools that gathered graduate, postgraduate students and researchers from partner universities with the aim to improve their knowledge on the EU integration process and to stimulate mobility and exchange of lecturers and young researchers from Montenegro, Serbia and Bosnia and Herzegovina.

The project further enhanced the education and scientific exchange through the signing of the memorandum of cooperation between the three faculties, and additionally through the development of a common curriculum and the establishment of a Balkan academic network. It encouraged as well the development of regional initiatives in educational academia and research and it supported the increase in volume of common educational tools and their regional exchange.



"International Congress on Nursing", implemented by Chamber of Nurses, Pristina



We all called them "heroes" during the pandemic, but have you ever thought of the psychological burden of health workers during the Covid-19 crises? What about the quality of life and stress of nurses during the epidemiological emergency in regional hospitals? What do we know on the effects it had on pregnant women or mothers who gave birth during the pandemic? What was the impact of (truncated) social support received during covid-19 pandemic on maternal postpartum depression? These were questions that did not cross people's mind on the

everyday life, but they certainly occupy the mind and affect those who provide the crucial health services mentioned above: nurses and midwives of our region.

From a caring and professional perspective, all these issues were discussed in the First Balkan Congress organized by the Chamber of Nurses, Midwives, and other Professionals in Kosovo – OIK, unveiling "The role, importance and challenges of nurses, midwives and other health professionals during the Covid-19 pandemic". An intensive event that brought together 25 presentations, in 4 sessions, with 8 professional moderators and 12 representatives from institutions and associations of nurses and midwives, from the 6 Balkan Contracting Parties, as well as Croatia, Slovenia and Turkey.



“The role of urban planning on migration”, implemented by EKONOMIKS, Pristina



The project aimed to address one of the significant aspects, considered a factor which is causing migration in the Western Balkans, and that is the quality of life in capital cities in the region: Belgrade, Pristina, Podgorica, Skopje, Sarajevo, and Tirana.

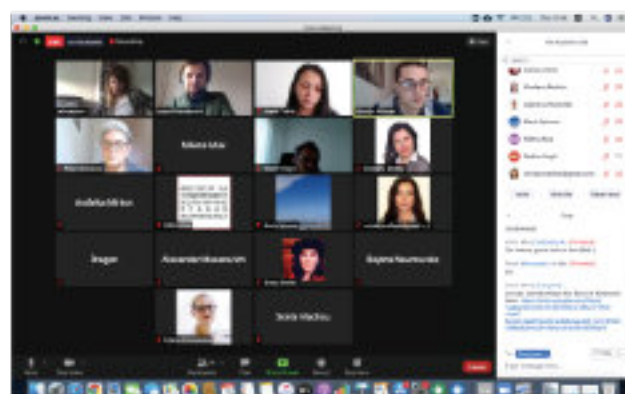
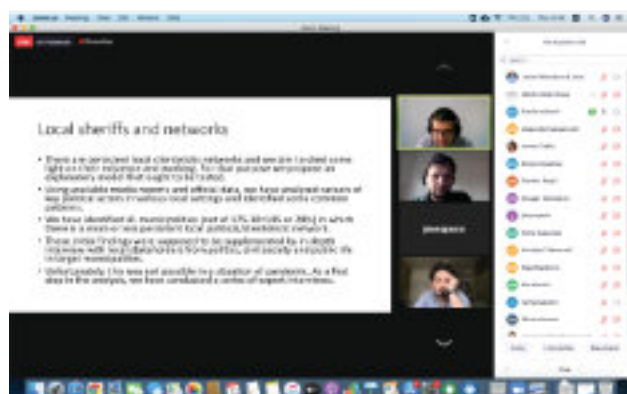
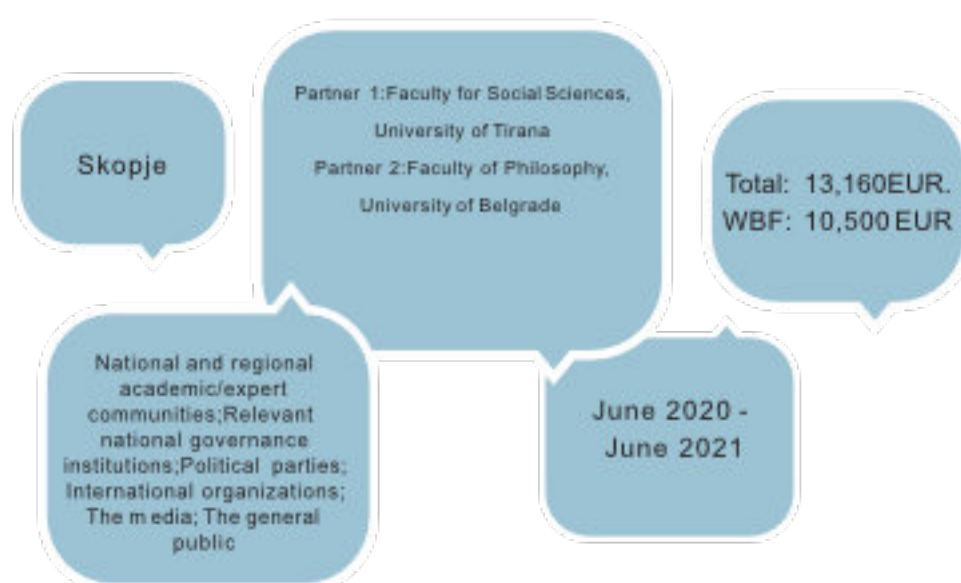
These cities share a common history, particularly in the last two decades when demographic changes have dramatically increased the need for expansion in the bigger cities and most cases this has exacerbated the urban planning process. Architects and urban planners are a valuable asset for societies, and with their professional approach, they can help to build functional cities. This project provided an opportunity for professionals (architects/urban planners) to expand their network in the region and to learn more about how societies in the region are coping with this phenomenon.



"Western Balkans Group on Political Clientelism", implemented by Institute for Sociological, Political and Juridical Research, Skopje



In what shapes and forms does political clientelism operate in the Western Balkans? 20 scholars have a good answer to that, and they shared in detail their research on political clientelism in our societies, in the activity organized by the Institute for Sociological, Political and Juridical Research, Ss. Cyril and Methodius University in Skopje). The scholars authored about 30 papers and shared their views in the series of discussion on the state of clientelism studies in the region. A very interesting approach, that captured the attention of more than 500 followers as the organizers launched the book "Studying Political Clientelism in the Western Balkans"!



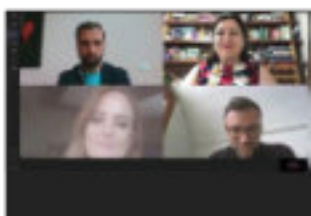
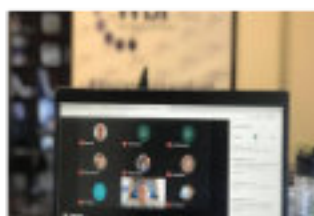
“Strengthening regional academic and research exchange”, implem ented by LUARASI UNIVERSITY,Tirana



“How regional University Cooperation can improve business cooperation – ideas, challenges and expectations – it was the core issue, dealt with in a number of academic ways, including forums and conference, part of the project “Strengthening Regional Academic and Research Exchange” between Luarasi University Albania, FON University in North Macedonia and University of Zenica in Bosnia and Herzegovina and Donja Gorica

University Montenegro! It was a great opportunity for everyone to reach the large assemblage of participants from academia, researchers, junior researchers, and other professionals.

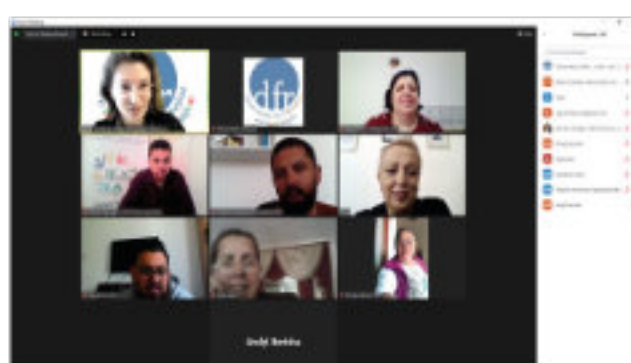
The academic events provided unique and rational opportunities to all the academics and researchers from the fields of Philosophy & Law, Economics, Information Technology & Innovation, Engineering, and others.



"Improving children rights monitoring mechanisms around Western Balkan region", implemented by OBSERVATORY FOR CHILDREN AND YOUTH RIGHTS, Tirana



The project aimed to introduce the Observatory initiative on monitoring the implementation of Children's Rights in three Contracting Parties of the Region, Kosovo*, North Macedonia and Serbia and to increase knowledge and skills of CSOs & activists concerning access to information on the implementation of children's rights.





SUSTAINABLE DEVELOPMENT

(32% OF TOTAL PROJECTS)

“Regional Capital (ReCaP)Market Conference”, implem ented by IMPACTHUB BELGRADE

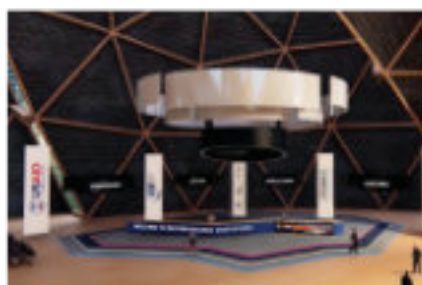
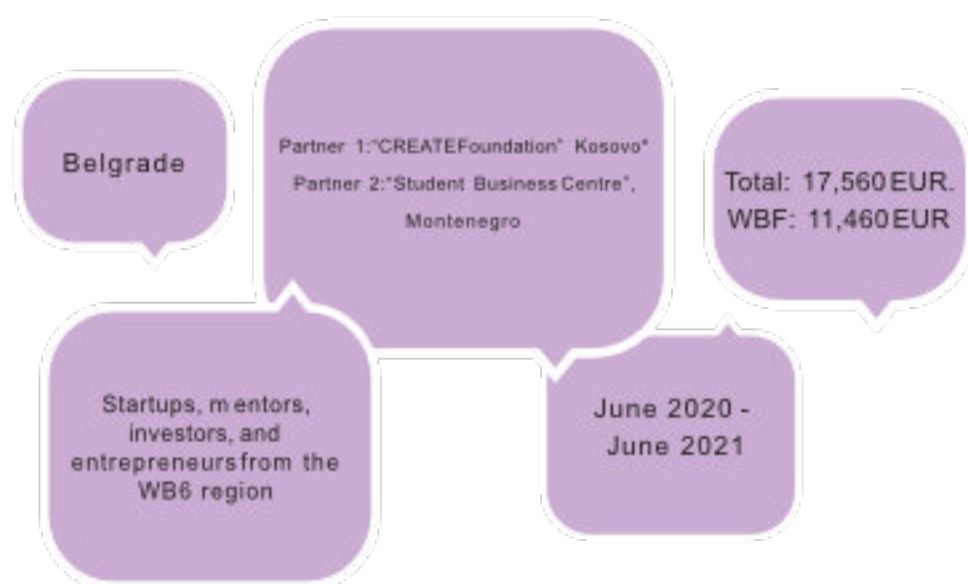
**IMPACT
HUB**

Project aimed to improve and strengthen regional innovation ecosystem for startups and innovative business initiatives in the Balkans, and as such it contributed to a sustainable and innovation based economic development and increase of competitiveness of the WB6 region startups at global market.

The proposed solution in reaching to project objectives foresaw realization of the Regional Capital Market Conference (ReCap), which increased access to alternative finance and investing (ie. Business angels, venture capitalists) for innovative startups and businesses.

ReCap created regional market opportunities for 60 start ups from the region with the purpose to accelerate start up innovation and growth to the markets of scale by providing the unique feed-forward methodology via agile mentoring sessions with international experts, startups and investors – 50 mentors, 20 investors, 150 entrepreneurs from the region.

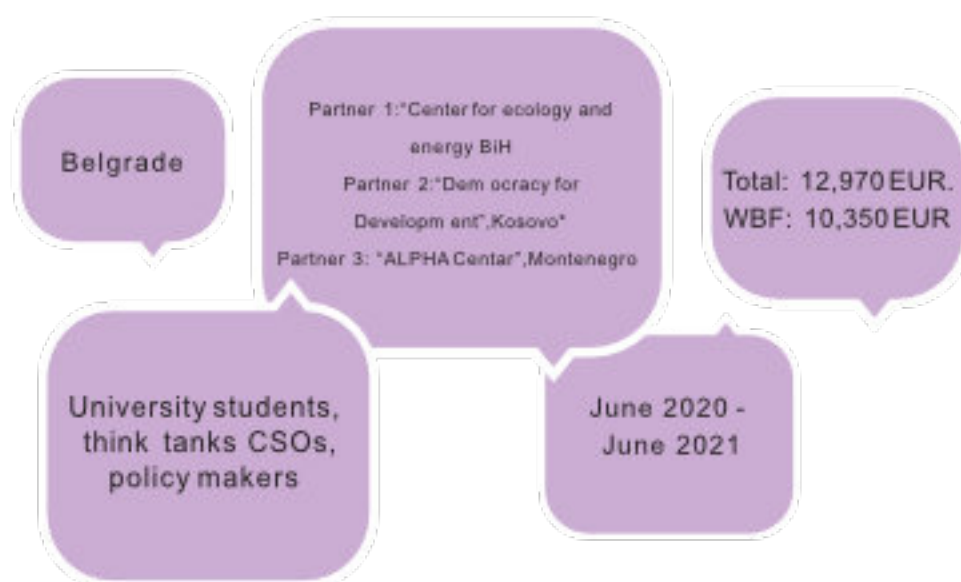
Moreover, the sustainability of the project was strengthened since the lead implementing Organization is a part of the global network with over 90 Impact hubs and 15000 community members, partners, mentors and investors from all over the world.



“Regional Green Youth Charter”, implemented by European Movement in Serbia



Can students take a more active role in fair transition to renewable energy production? Can they develop advocating tools on Regional Green Youth Charter (RGYC)? European Movement Serbia proved that they can, with the adequate training and support by donors and partners. This is exactly what the project “Regional Green Youth Charter” did, under the inspiring guidance of the European Movement in Serbia and the project partners from Bosnia and Herzegovina, Kosovo* and Montenegro. EMS conducted impactful trainings and activities with students to raise awareness of youth on importance of transition to renewable energy production. These empowered trainees are now taking a more active role in their local communities towards fair transition to renewable energy production.



“Strengthening role of women in promoting peace and cooperation in Western Balkan region through capacity building and education”, implemented by Centre for Local and Regional Development Support, Herceg Novi



Is the chain as strong as its' weakest link? No! It is much stronger if all links are represented by women. An outstanding group of women demonstrated exactly this side, as they worked together to promote peace, reconciliation, and cooperation in Western Balkans. But how? By having the first and last say in a series of events that contribute to increasing women activism and capacity building.

Lead by a group of active women from civil society in Montenegro, Bosnia and Herzegovina and Serbia, this initiative, supported by the Western Balkans Fund is contributing to women's participation in reconciliation process in WB region through capacity building and education.

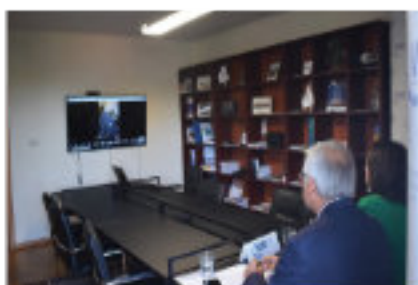


"Regional Investment Promotion", implemented by Chamber of Doing Business (ODA), Pristina



What is the impact of Covid-19 in the regional business cooperation? How it is being addressed? What have we learned, as we define the best modalities and ways to increase the cooperation? All these questions were answered at the Regional Conference dedicated to the impact of Covid-19

Pandemic on the business and economic situation in the Western Balkans, one of the many events organized by ODA.



“Regional Cooperation on Global Consulting Day 2020”, implemented by Business Consulting Council, Pristina



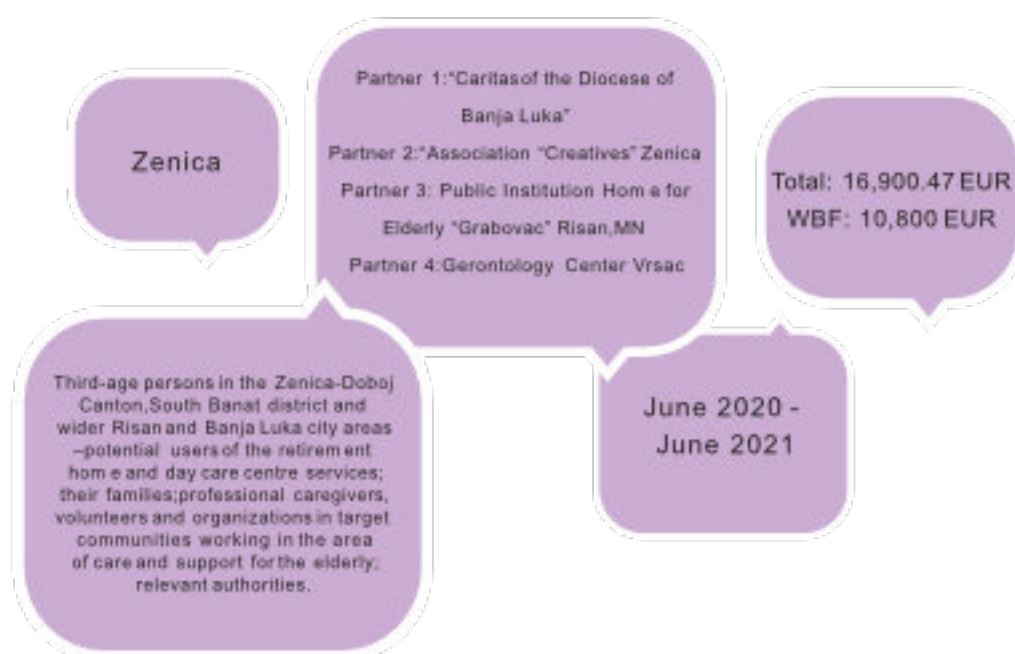
The project aimed to link and enhance the management consulting capacities by exchanging the best practices from Kosovo*, Albania and North Macedonia through the implementation of the very first regional conference for Global Consulting Day. This joint event, consisted in a regional conference and seminar, gathering both management consultants and business community (up to 150 participants), to canalize the ways of cooperation and leak the projects, activities and services that the consultants could benefit from each other and at the same time learn from the strategic actions undertaken by the success stories of partners.



“Healthy Aging”, implemented by Public institution “Retirement Home with a Stationary” in Zenica-doboj Canton, Zenica



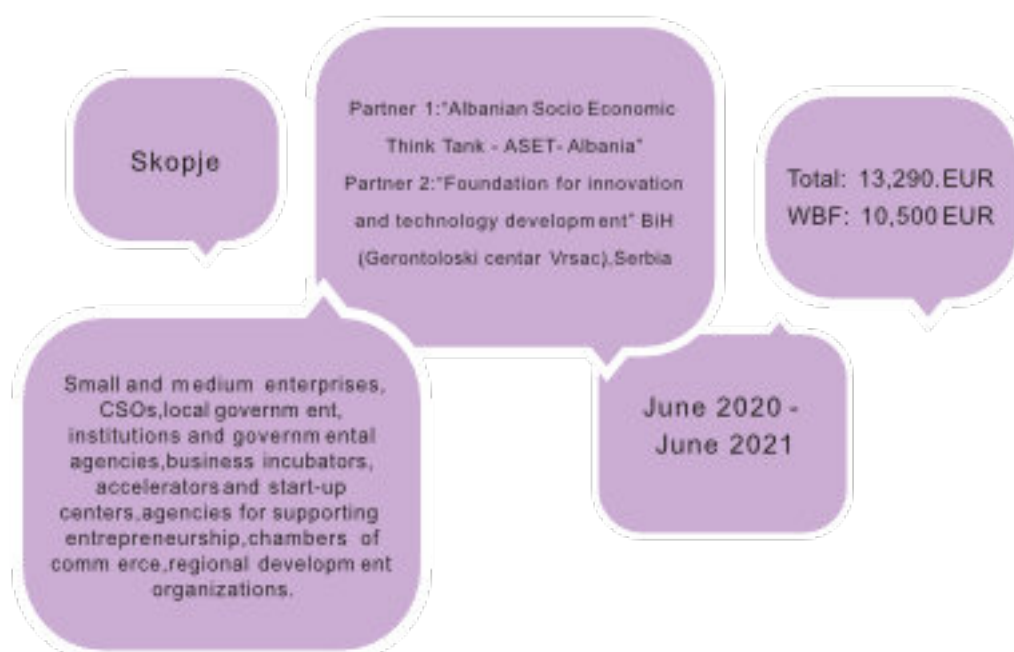
Our beloved elderlies deserve to have an active and healthy lifestyle. Hence, ZDK Retirement Home took the initiative to bring a livelier approach to the third age group in our region. Their meaningful efforts were made in cooperation with the Association “Creatives” from Zenica, Banja Luka Archdiocese - CARITAS Banja, Gerontology Center Vrsac (Serbia), Home for the Elderly and Grabovac Risan (Montenegro). All sought to contribute to regional cooperation and healthy aging. It is visible the improved quality of life and creativity of the elderly in the target communities through workshops on photography, painting and other recreational activities for a healthier and dignified aging!



"Partnership for circular economy – sustainable SMEs growth and regional development", implemented by YOUTH ENTREPRENEURIAL SERVICE FOUNDATION (YES FOUNDATION), Skopje



What are your thoughts on the circular economy? Our implementing partners from the Youth Entrepreneurial Service Foundation (Yes Foundation) in Skopje introduced the circular economy concept and have started to build skills among businesses and CSOs for transition to circular economy. Amongst other benefits, circular economy contributes to job creation and sustainable development. With the adequate support and promotion, the circular economy concept has proven to be an effective new approach in enhancing regional development through networking and strengthening SMEs and CSO capacities around it. The project is passionate about increasing the capacities of 60 SMEs and CSOs for implementing the circular economy concept into their businesses, to raise awareness amongst 70 others and to create new job opportunities on long-term.



Supporting partners growth

Despite the situation created by the Covid 19 Pandemic, when possible, WBF remained committed to conducting monitoring and evaluation of its grants, for several reasons:

- (a) to best support its grantees and help them understand the impact they are making to improve their effectiveness
- (b) to better discover how to adapt its approach to meet the needs of its stakeholders and
- (c) to build internal capacity to enable WBF to consistently strive for excellence in how it conducts its operations.

In order to deliver on its strategic ambitions, WBF has decided to invest in the development of a tailored monitoring, evaluation and learning (MEL) system.

This system is intended to contribute to WBF's programmatic development; improve the effectiveness of its grant-making programming and outcomes, and increase accountability.

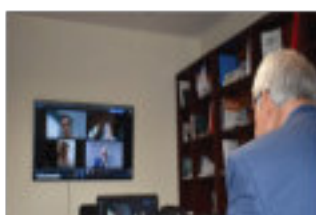


Networking within and beyond the WB Region

WBF understands networking as a tool to establish and nurture long-term, mutually beneficial relationships with its stakeholders.

Even though the sense of normality was challenged and the mobility limited, WBF, in 2020 has put significant efforts to foster its professional connections throughout the region and has positioned as one important actor in the regional cooperation processes in Western Balkans.

Through its active participation, WBF managed to be part physically or virtually of over 80 most important processes, initiatives, conferences, annual meetings, summits and bilateral meetings with different stakeholders within the region and beyond.





Organizational Development – WBF Partners International Visegrad Fund

Since its establishment, International Visegrad Fund has provided WBF with Technical Assistance, supporting mainly WBF promotional activities and mobility in the region.

In the framework of the ongoing cooperation between the two institutions, the Memorandum of Understanding for the Second Technical Assistance Program (February 2020 – December 2021) was signed in Prague, on February 27, 2020.

The partnership between the two Funds is consolidating beyond the financial and technical nature. The communication and exchange are getting stronger and mutual events are being organized periodically, such as the Joint Annual Meeting of the IVF National Coordinators and WBF Council of Senior Officials.

Also, in the framework of the exchange of expertise and of strengthening the cooperation at the expert's level, WBF staff has actively participated in several occasions at the IVF project assessment sessions.



Peace Nexus Foundation

WBF Secretariat is closely working with the Peace Nexus Foundation in terms of coordination of WBF activities along with definition of the WBF's needs for the Secretariat's work improvement and fundraising efforts. With the financial and mentoring support of the Peace Nexus Foundation, several important activities were or are being organized, such as:

- The design of the WBF mid-term Strategic and Development Plan;
- Capacity and Organizational Development workshops and retreats;
- development of a tailored monitoring, evaluation and learning (MEL) system through the recruitment of a MEL expert etc



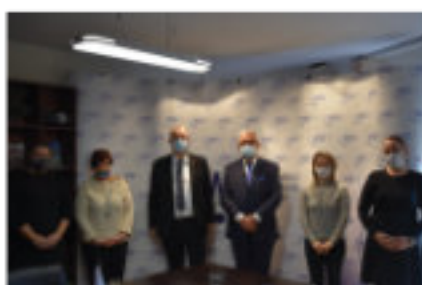
Embassy of Switzerland in Tirana

WBF has established and nurtured good relationship with the Swiss Embassy in Tirana and the Swiss Embassies all over the WB Region, not limited only at informative level, but also for exploring potential areas of collaboration, based on mutual interest.

At the end of 2019, Swiss Federal Department of Foreign Affairs (FDFA), represented by the Embassy of Switzerland in Albania, supported WBF with a small grant as a direct provision to WBF's actions, and aiming the improvement of the Fund's overall performance.

FDFA support facilitated WBF to enhance its presence in all contracting parties, especially the promotion of its 3rd Call for Proposals and the purchase of technical equipment for the WBF staff, critical for its on-line working, during the COVID-19 Pandemic.

This direct support is considered by both parties as a good and unique opportunity to get familiar with each others respective rules and procedures, aiming a more substantial and long-term cooperation in the future.



Beyond Grants – WBF Implementing... Western Balkans Civil Society Summit

With the financial support of the Ministry of Foreign affairs of Japan in Tirana, on 27-29 February 2020, Western Balkans Fund organized the Western Balkans Civil Society Summit. More than 100 civil society representatives gathered together to discuss about the future development of the region and the civil society sector to better enhance the regional cooperation. During these days many panels were held with high representatives from the governments, from different sectors, and also high representatives of international and regional organizations in the region, to discuss with the representatives which are some of the challenges and success until now and conclude with recommendations for the governments.

Participants came from all over the region, bringing their best experiences and providing great contribution to the Summit. A full day was dedicated to the working groups, providing the participants with an opportunity to discuss among each other and tackle some of the most important challenges regarding regional cooperation.



Report on Impact of Covid 19on sustainability of Civil Society Organizations in Western Balkans

Covid-19pandemic has affected Civil Society Organizations in a number of ways. The most frequent challenges are linked with disruption, discontent and discovery, as the main processes related to the crisis. CSOs experienced various forms of it in the cancelled projects, downsizing, new work mode, lack of official economic assistance and at times, deprivation of fundamental freedoms. However, in the midst of the crisis, CSOs were capable to adapt to online options, show resilience and solidarity and enjoy to a good extent, donor flexibility.

From there, with lessons learned on resilience, reflection and revitalization, CSOs are ready to embrace flexibility, creativity and adaptation skills as they move forward and reflect on comprehensive crisis preparation processes, and more importantly, on revitalizing new strategic alliances and better aligned agendas.

These were the main points of the report on the "Impact of COVID-19 on sustainability of Civil Society Organization in the Western Balkans region".

Through the kind support of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs of Japan, during the period December 2020 - March 2021, WBF implemented the project "Impact of COVID-19 on sustainability of Civil Society Organizations in Western Balkans Region".

As part of this project WBF received over 50 research papers from the region, where 18 research papers were selected and supported, while the findings, analyses and conclusions were used, alongside other materials, to compile the Regional Report.

The aim of the Regional Report was to depict a picture of the situation of Civil Society Organizations in the Western Balkans during the Covid-19 pandemic. How has the pandemic impacted the sector and in what ways already existing challenges have been aggravated by the crisis? Has there been a silver lining in the situation where CSOs could benefit, or at least make the best, of it?

Within this broader scheme, the Report is particularly focused with the regional cooperation perspective in the Western Balkans. How regional cooperation has been affected by the pandemic? How the work of CSOs involved in regional projects has been impeded and how the shift towards digital and other virtual event planning enabled regional cooperation on a new level? The study is based upon the analysis of 18 case study reports, looking at the impact of Covid-19 on CSOs within local and regional contexts and presents a selected amount of case studies and will identify common challenges, opportunities and best practice from the region.

Most importantly, the Report led towards a set of Recommendations aimed to enable regional cooperation and to strengthen CSOs role, during the pandemic and beyond. The report deals with the sustainability, similarities and differences identified in how CSOs in the region are dealing with it; ways forward in virtual times for regional cooperation; adjustment needs in funding schemes and crisis management, joint regional programs on the issues identified, etc.

Report Co-authors: Mrs. Alba Cela and Mr. Zoran Nechev.



Western Balkans Fund Internship Program

Additional support that WBF is keen to provide is youth empowerment. In the year 2020, with the International Visegrad Fund support, WBF launched the Second Internship Program, in order to enable youngsters from the Western Balkans region to gain first-hand exposure of working in the real world and in a regional environment. Additionally, to allow them to harness the skill, knowledge, and theoretical practice they learnt during their studies. This internship support provided them with a nice learning curve for three very talented youngsters. WBF opened a Call for Interns and conducted a serious evaluation process with a huge number of applicants.



Visibility Actions

Promotion of WBF's actions focuses on obtaining a wider public outreach and is conducted based on following elements:

- **Aware** - People know we exist, meaning WBF; (newsletter, annual reports, press conferences, website hyperlink, interviews on media, visit to the website, shares on Facebook, and comments)
- **Interested** - People give us permission to communicate with them (WBF Facebook Partnership Platform, visits in WBF office, direct emails, and Facebook followers)
- **Engaged** - People take action to support regional cause (apply for WBF Calls, direct emails, share our news, give comments, and participate in WBF's events such as Information Sessions, Conferences etc).

Social Media - WBF nowadays encounters 12,300 followers in Facebook page, with 2,000 followers in Twitter and 1,661 followers in Instagram. WBF is active and regular in providing information to its followers on daily basis and publishes declarations, press releases, publications, documents, and instructions in real time.

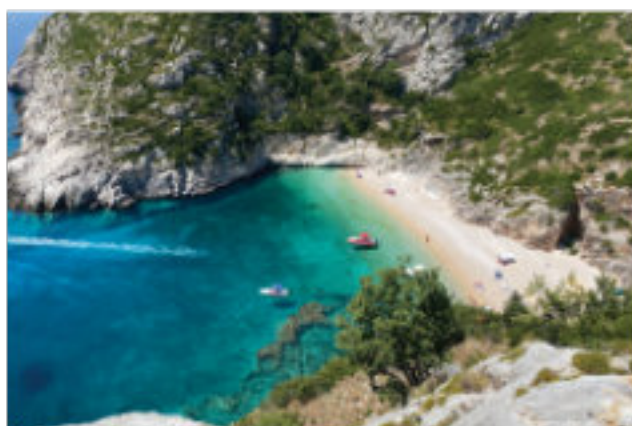
Newsletter - Western Balkans Fund Secretariat prepares and produces its Newsletter on monthly basis and it is shared with all stakeholders within the region and beyond. This promotional tool helped WBF to establish relationships and maintain regular contact with stakeholders, donor community, governments and beneficiaries and it is distributed each month to over 5,000 e-mails addresses.

Western Balkans through my eyes

In December 2020 WBF launched the Photo Competition "Western Balkans Through my eyes", inviting all interested photographers from the region to submit photos that "tell a story" of what it means to be a citizen of Western Balkans and provide a sense of what it is like to live in this region.

85 participants and more than 400 photos received and the winning photos were used to design the WBF annual calendar.

Through this photo competition, the participants found a way to virtually present the beautiful features of this beautiful region, unfortunately difficult to enjoy in real life during this difficult challenging year.



Erazma Gjokopuli: "Grama Bay"



Nemin Pjevo: "Bascarsija, Sarajevo"



Valdrina Segojeva: "Prishtina at Night"



Nikola Blečić: "Kolasin"



Teodora Mladenoska: "Rosoman"



Ana Batricevic: "Kalemegdan Fortress"



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